

YOUR MENOPAUSE STAGE

Where you are on the **menopause map** — and **what happens next**

Menopause isn't a single moment. It's a transition of several years, staged by clinicians using your **bleeding pattern** — not a blood test. Here is the map, the criteria for each stage, and roughly how long each one lasts.

Premenopause

REGULAR CYCLES

Early peri

VARIES ≥ 7 DAYS

Late peri

GAPS 60+ DAYS

Postmenopause

12 MONTHS, NONE

STAGE 01 • STRAW -3

Premenopause**Criteria:** cycles still regular and predictable

Fertility declines quietly while hormones stay broadly stable. Knowing your normal cycle length now makes the first changes easy to spot later. Typically ends in the mid-40s (median age 47).

STAGE 02 • STRAW -2

Early perimenopause**Criteria:** persistent change of 7+ days in cycle length

The first formal marker of the transition. Periods arrive noticeably earlier or later than usual. Symptoms often begin here — even while periods still come most months. The whole transition typically runs 4–7 years.

STAGE 03 • STRAW -1

Late perimenopause**Criteria:** gaps of 60 days or more between periods

You start skipping periods. Hot flashes and other symptoms usually peak here, and this stage is the most responsive to treatment. Typically lasts 1–3 years before the final period.

STAGE 04 • STRAW +1

Postmenopause**Criteria:** 12 consecutive months with no period

Menopause is confirmed — on average around age 51. Oestrogen settles low and stays there. Symptoms often ease over 2–5 years, but bone and heart health now deserve active attention.

Why not just test your hormones? Because in perimenopause they swing. In the landmark SWAN study, researchers found four different oestradiol trajectories — and **44.6% of women saw oestradiol rise** before their final period rather than fall. A test on a high day reads "normal"; the same woman a week later can read menopausal. This is why NICE advises against using FSH to diagnose perimenopause in women over 45 with typical symptoms.

TAKE THIS TO YOUR APPOINTMENT

Your 7-day symptom tracker

Clinicians read symptoms, not single numbers. Rate each symptom daily from **0 (none)** to **3 (severe)**. One clear week of data is worth more than any one blood test — and it makes the conversation with your doctor far more productive.

SYMPTOM	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
Hot flushes Physical	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Night sweats Physical	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sleep problems Physical	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Joint & muscle aches Physical	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Mood swings / irritability Psychological	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Anxiety or low mood Psychological	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Brain fog / memory Psychological	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Fatigue / exhaustion Psychological	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Vaginal dryness Urogenital	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Low libido Urogenital	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Bladder changes Urogenital	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Period this day? Note flow: light / normal / heavy	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

BEFORE YOUR APPOINTMENT

- ☐ **Date of your last period** — and the one before it
- ☐ **Your usual cycle length**, and how much it now varies
- ☐ **This tracker**, filled in for at least one week
- ☐ **Your top three symptoms**, ranked by impact on daily life
- ☐ **Family history** — age your mother reached menopause

WORTH ASKING YOUR DOCTOR

- ☐ Which **stage** do my cycle and symptoms suggest?
- ☐ Is **HRT** suitable for me — benefits and risks in my case?
- ☐ What **non-hormonal options** are worth trying?
- ☐ Should we check **thyroid, iron or vitamin D** too?
- ☐ What should I do to protect **bone and heart health**?

▲ See a doctor sooner if any of these apply

- **Menopausal symptoms or absent periods before age 40** — this may be premature ovarian insufficiency and should be assessed promptly.
- **Any bleeding after 12 months without a period** — postmenopausal bleeding is never normal and needs checking.
- **Very heavy or prolonged bleeding**, bleeding between periods, or bleeding after sex.

PUT IT TO WORK

Find your stage — free & interactive

Tool → testosteroneblueprintguide.com/menopause-stage-quiz · Full method → [The Hormone Blueprint](#)

Disclaimer: This tracker is educational and is not medical advice or a diagnosis. Symptoms have many possible causes.

Discuss your results, and any treatment, with a qualified clinician who knows your history.